24
Internal Security and Countering Terrorism

The Indian Army has a long experience in handling insurgency, terrorism and other forms of low-intensity conflict. This area has been my forte. I have had hands-on experience in counterinsurgency operations in Nagaland in the 1960s as a young officer, in Tirap district of Arunachal Pradesh in the 1980s while leading a battalion, and as a brigade commander in Kashmir in 1991–92. This experience helped me make a handsome contribution towards bringing down the level of violence and contain terrorism in J&K and the northeast. However, such challenges are comparatively new for many armies; and therefore, we see that the campaigns of the multinational forces in Afghanistan and Iraq have been extremely costly not only in terms of human lives but also financially. These wars have of late acquired serious political undertones along with a big price tag. Further, the end does not seem to be in sight.

In an asymmetric war, the preponderance of firepower does not give the same advantage as would be the case in conventional warfare. In such conflicts there is no front, and the adversary follows no rules. He can appear from anywhere, and may not even be recognizable. Very often he uses innocent citizens as human shields. When we look at urban insurgency that we are confronted with in parts of J&K or the northeast of India, or for that matter by the multinational forces in Afghanistan, the messy situations that the soldiers have to confront so often are unbelievable, and at times unimaginable! Those of us who have conducted such operations have been through some of these unpleasant experiences. Furthermore, there are no manuals to guide our junior leaders or troops in effectively handling various delicate and tricky situations